

Independent Software Support System

Product Design

A shared product for voluntary financial support across independently published software

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Status: Product design baseline
Date: 4 September 2026

Product decision

This system is the primary way I will invite people to pay for software that I also make available free of charge. It belongs to my software business. Games, DR Companion, the auto grader, the book reader, and later products integrate with it as clients. No single application owns the business rules, payment language, pricing logic, measurement definitions, or support history.

The system asks after it can state, with numbers, what a person has used or completed. It then offers contribution amounts expressed as a dated United States reference price for familiar McDonald's food. The food comparison communicates that the contribution is personal income used for ordinary living expenses, including food. It is not a claim of charitable status and does not imply an affiliation with McDonald's.

Business objective

The system must turn demonstrated product value into voluntary payment while protecting the conditions that make the request credible. The complete software remains available without payment. A contribution does not unlock functionality, improve treatment, or remove an artificial inconvenience.

Objective	How it is measured	Constraint
Increase completed contributions	Confirmed payments divided by eligible support presentations	A checkout opening is not a payment
Increase expected revenue	Confirmed contribution value divided by eligible support presentations	Report currency and time period
Preserve trust	Dismissals, permanent opt outs, complaints, and repeat voluntary visits	No obstructed decline path
Work across products	Number of real product integrations using the canonical package	No copied product specific implementations
Tell the truth	Every displayed fact resolves to recorded data or a disclosed calculation	Unknown values are omitted

Human exchange

The payment request connects the software to a meal for the person who made it. The comparison is concrete because a payer can understand buying another person food. The system does not use food as a decorative theme, a loyalty reward, or a vague purchasing power analogy. It identifies what the contribution can buy for me.

The fry calculation creates a low stakes way to enter the page and demonstrates that even the smallest unit has a real value. It must not conceal the amount charged. Opening a wallet is the principal act of commitment, so the primary checkout asks for a useful contribution tied to a recognizable meal. The exact amount comes from a

documented United States price study performed on a stated date; this design does not assign a nominal ten dollar price or any other invented price.

User promise

- The software is complete and usable without contributing.
- The page explains what the user did with the product using recorded numbers and facts.
- Contribution amounts and currency are visible before checkout.
- The page explains that contributions are personal income used for ordinary living expenses.
- The user can decline immediately and can disable automatic presentations.
- Usage facts remain on the device unless a separate, explicit analytics decision is approved.
- The system never claims that a contribution is charitable or tax deductible unless the legal business structure later makes that statement true.

The support moment

An application may make a person eligible after it has recorded enough evidence to describe substantial use. Eligibility does not itself open the page. The host application proposes a safe moment after a completed activity. The shared policy decides whether an automatic presentation is allowed.

State	Required behavior
Not yet eligible	The manual support page may exist, but no automatic request appears.
Eligible but busy	Wait. Do not interrupt work, play, reading, grading, saving, checkout, recovery, or an error.
Eligible at a completed activity	The host may propose a support presentation.
Recently dismissed	Respect the configured cooldown and do not intensify the message.
Automatic requests disabled	Never present automatically. Keep a manual Support entry.
Paid edition	Thank the purchaser. Automatic requests are disabled by default.
Payment confirmed	Show the confirmed amount and a short thank you, then return to the product.

Initial page structure

1. Name the product and show verified use totals.
2. Show a compact facts section generated from product supplied metrics.
3. Explain that the software is free and that contributions help pay ordinary living expenses.
4. Show the United States price study date and methodology disclosure.
5. Present the recommended full meal contribution with its exact amount.
6. Present smaller food based amounts without hiding their exact values.
7. Provide the fry calculation with visible inputs and units.
8. Provide a custom amount, a normal decline action, and a permanent automatic opt out.
9. State the local usage data, dated price study, payment, and trademark qualifications.

Facts section

The phrase During this time is not followed by generated atmosphere or an inferred narrative. It introduces a compact set of numeric facts supplied by the product, including hours and counts of completed work or objectives by meaningful type. The shared system formats them but does not invent, estimate, or embellish them.

Product	Candidate facts	Facts excluded without evidence
Pirate Island	Active play time; completed sessions; objectives completed by type; campaigns completed; factions eliminated; locations captured; dungeons cleared	Emotional impact, difficulty, importance, or events not present in the save
DR Companion	Connected time; completed connected sessions; routes, tasks, or other defined actions completed by type	Time with the shell open, inferred enjoyment, or private game text
Auto grader	Active work time; grading sessions completed; submissions processed; grading actions completed by type; reports exported	Hours saved unless a measured baseline exists; student content
Book reader	Active reading or listening time; sessions completed; works completed; pages or locations advanced; reader actions completed by type	Comprehension, attention, benefit, or private reading content

Each product approves its own fact definitions before release. A field with unknown, partial, or disputed semantics is omitted. Zero may be displayed when zero is meaningful and verified; missing data must not be converted to zero.

Value receipt order	Displayed fact	Evidence rule
1	Active time and measurement coverage dates	Derived from eligible active intervals; identify partial coverage
2	Meaningful sessions completed	Count only sessions that meet the product's approved completion rule
3	Completed work or objectives	Show the total and a reconciliation by approved type
4	Additional product-specific outcomes	Display only stored, reproducible events with stable definitions

This value receipt precedes the request for money. Its purpose is to substantiate what the software has actually done with the user, not to assign an invented cash value to the user's time or outcomes.

Contribution choices

The food scale gives the user concrete reference points. The first release supports the following canonical choices. Availability in the defined United States study may require a clearly named equivalent or omission.

Choice	Purpose	Price rule	Presentation
One french fry	Smallest conceptual unit, transparent calculation, and entry into the support decision	Derived from a matching fries price, serving mass, and estimated fry mass	Show the math; never conceal the actual checkout amount
Ice cream cone	Low contribution	Dated United States reference price or omitted	Secondary choice
Hamburger without cheese	Modest contribution	Dated United States reference price or omitted	Secondary choice
Kid's meal	Midrange contribution	Dated United States reference price using a defined product	Expanded choice
Quarter Pounder with Cheese meal	Recommended full meal contribution	Dated United States reference price using a	Primary choice with sincere

Choice	Purpose	Price rule	Presentation
		defined meal	thanks
Custom amount	User controlled contribution	Entered explicitly and validated by the payment provider	Always available

Fry calculation

The system calculates the estimated value of one fry from mass. The price and serving mass must describe the same product size in the same market. The estimated fry mass must identify its method and sample.

$$\text{estimated fry value} = \text{serving price} \times \text{estimated fry mass} / \text{serving mass}$$

The expanded row shows the substituted values, units, unrounded result, currency rounding, data dates, and source labels. The 4 September 2026 provisional release uses a \$3.56 national medium-fries reference, a published 112 gram average serving mass, and a published average count of 78 fries. This gives an estimated mass of 1.435897 grams per fry and an unrounded value of \$0.045641, displayed as about \$0.05. If any required input is unavailable or stale, the fry option is unavailable rather than fabricated.

United States reference pricing

The first release uses a United States reference price observed on a named date. It does not request or infer the user's location. The page defines what average means, identifies the restaurants and ordering channel included in the study, reports the sample size, and retains the observations used to calculate the result.

1. Define the population and the sampling frame for United States restaurant prices.
2. Define the restaurant channel, product configuration, tax treatment, and observation window.
3. Collect attributable observations on the stated date or during a disclosed date range.
4. Publish the sample size, missing observations, arithmetic mean, median, minimum, and maximum.
5. Use the arithmetic mean as the displayed average only when the methodology approves it.
6. Store the underlying evidence and the exact calculation with the released price table.
7. Display the observation date beside the amount and stop calling an old study current.

Food reference	Published amount	Coverage and source
One french fry	\$0.05 displayed; \$0.045641 unrounded	Derived from a \$3.56 medium-fries mean across 13,595 reported U.S. locations and a separate 10-order mass-and-count experiment
Vanilla cone	\$2.31	MenuPriceTracker mean across 13,503 reported U.S. locations; updated 28 August 2026
Hamburger without cheese	\$2.89	MenuPriceToday delivery-platform aggregate across about 472 U.S. locations; September 2026
Hamburger Happy Meal	\$6.19	MenuPriceToday delivery-platform aggregate across about 472 U.S. locations; September 2026
Quarter Pounder with Cheese meal	\$12.19	MenuPriceToday delivery-platform aggregate across about 472 U.S. locations; September 2026

These are independent national references retrieved 4 September 2026, before tax. They are not McDonald's corporate prices or a quote for the user's nearest restaurant. The source channels and samples differ, so the system preserves each row's provenance and does not pool them into a new average.

Tone and visual direction

The page looks like part of the software business, not like McDonald's and not like a game reward screen. It uses the host product's typography and layout system. The factual totals receive the strongest typographic emphasis. The recommended contribution is clear but not animated, preselected, or described with unsupported popularity claims.

- Use plain food names and small neutral icons only when they improve scanning.
- Do not use McDonald's logos, packaging, photography, typography, color system, or trade dress.
- Do not use countdowns, scarcity, guilt, sad characters, blocked exits, or repeated refusals.
- Do not write fictional user stories. Show measured facts.
- Keep Not today visible and keyboard accessible.
- Place detailed methodology and qualifications behind readable disclosure controls, while keeping the exact amount visible.

Payment experience

The page separates the amount comparison from the charge. A person may explore the value of one fry, but the checkout action always states the complete amount that will be charged and the food reference that amount can buy according to the dated United States study. A fry interaction may select, expand, or begin composing a contribution. It cannot transform into a meal sized charge without a second, explicit confirmation.

1. The user selects an amount in the product.
2. The product repeats the product name, amount, currency, and payment provider.
3. The provider opens with the amount prefilled when supported.
4. The provider handles payment credentials.
5. Only a verified provider result counts as a completed contribution.
6. Cancellation returns the user to the support page with the selection intact.
7. Confirmation states the amount received or charged according to an approved accounting rule and thanks the user without spectacle.

Cross product architecture

Layer	Owns	Does not own
Support core	Event reduction, active time, eligibility, price-study records, calculation, preferences, fact validation	Product specific activity semantics or visual skin
Product adapter	Meaningful session, active state, approved metrics, safe presentation moments	Payment credentials or independent support policy
Presentation adapter	Native components, typography, accessibility integration	Different business rules
Payment adapter	Checkout creation, supported currency, confirmation and cancellation	Usage history
Price-study registry	Dated United States observations, item mapping, provenance, statistics and publication status	Payment or product usage data

Failure and recovery

Failure	Required result
Clock changes	Use monotonic elapsed time within a session and wall clock only for persisted dates.
Application crash	Recover from the last checkpoint and never add the unknown interval.
Price evidence unavailable	Show the page without a current United States price claim and retain custom contribution.
Menu item unavailable	Omit it or name a disclosed equivalent; do not fabricate a price.
Payment cancelled	Return without recording payment or punishing the user.
Payment result unknown	Show a neutral pending state and reconcile through the provider.
Old or migrated usage history	Identify partial coverage; do not imply the totals cover earlier unrecorded use.

Accessibility requirements

- Every amount is expressed in text and programmatically associated with its action.
- The recommended option is identified by words and structure, not color alone.
- All controls work by keyboard, touch, pointer, and screen reader.
- Focus returns to the invoking control after dismissal or cancelled checkout.
- Expanded calculations have a readable sentence equivalent.
- The page respects reduced motion and does not rely on motion to attract payment.
- Currency, decimal separators, units, dates, and reading direction are localized.

Release stages

Stage	Demonstrable result	Exit criteria
Core prototype	Recorded sessions and active time survive restart	Deterministic tests cover start, stop, idle, crash checkpoint, and migration
Manual support page	One product shows verified facts and configured amounts	No invented values; keyboard and screen reader review complete
Payment integration	A real contribution can complete and reconcile	Sandbox and production paths tested; secrets absent from clients
Reference pricing	A dated United States price study yields auditable menu facts	Population, sample, source, calculation, date, and disclosure verified
Shared adoption	A second product uses the same core	No copied policy or calculation code; adapters remain product specific
Conversion program	Variants can be compared from real funnel outcomes	Metrics and consent approved; guardrails monitored

Decision status

Accepted: a shared, complete-without-payment product that states recorded value and uses a visibly calculated fry-to-meal scale. The 4 September 2026 United States reference is provisional. Open decisions are the payment provider, presentation rules, a retained multi-location fry measurement, and analytics consent.